

out again. I finally got on the plane.

What was your impression of Hong Kong?

Very crowded. I offered to donate a trampoline to the school, and they said they didn't have room for it [he laughs for a long time at this recollection]. I wasn't wild about it, but I decided I would go anyway. I tried to get myself psyched about going, but I just couldn't do it. I decided I needed to go back to Hong Kong to check it out again. It was a replay of my first visit. I spent five months trying to get myself to go to Hong Kong. I became depressed. I lost 45 pounds.

Boy, you really didn't want this job.

This was the first time in my life that I decided to do something mentally that was in conflict with my emotions. My body just stopped me in my tracks. I didn't realize it, but there was no way I could go to Hong Kong. Rohm & Haas had a coach who did assessments of managers to see if they had the right profile to be CEO. During this period, she was talking to me on the phone and asked me a number of questions. She said, "Tom, I think you are clinically depressed. You need to see a psychiatrist. You need to do it right away." She found me a doctor who placed me on antidepressants. Finally, I went to Rohm & Haas—I was probably down to about 135 pounds by that time, and I looked like death—and I told them that I couldn't take the job in Hong Kong.

When did you come out of your depression?

Very quickly after I turned the job down.

That did it?

That plus the antidepressants. I had a friend who had gone through depression, and as soon as he realized that I was going through depression myself, he gave me advice. He said, "Look Tom, here's what you have to do. I went through all this counseling, and all I can tell you is just get the drugs." After I had taken the antidepressant for about two weeks, the cloud lifted, and I could see again.

Was that the only episode of depression you had?

The only one.